

Outstanding Leadership

The Northern Powerhouse

Expect outstanding

Outstanding Leadership, The Northern Powerhouse

Our white paper, ‘Outstanding Leadership, The Northern Powerhouse’, is a snapshot of organisations and individuals, during one of the most challenging times that we’re likely to experience as leaders.

We’ve brought together an insightful narrative that transgresses industry verticals, in a time where the world needs authentic role models.

I want to thank the contributors for taking part in this white paper and sharing their stories.

Rachel Mcelroy
CMO, Solutionize Global

Contents

02	Foreword by Roger Marsh OBE DL
04	Market conditions
05	Riaan De Klerk, CDO, Solutionize Global
06	Our contributors
08	The Northern Powerhouse
10	Matt Kelleher, CIO, WM Morrisons Plc
12	Samantha Robinson, Interim Associate Director, Live Services NHS Digital
14	Sinead Rocks, Managing Director, Nations & Regions, Channel 4
16	Amanda and Simon Cookson, Founders, Northern Value Creators
17	Dan Kirkland, CEO, Tribepad
18	Leadership principles
20	Matthew Kent, Operations Director, Siemens
22	Rashmi Dubé, Partner, Gunnercooke LLP
23	Mel Kanarek, Co-founder and Director, Sheffield Digital
24	Rik Barker, CIO, Flutter Group Plc
26	Charlotte Bailey, COO, Panintelligence
28	Jordan Appleson & Mike Jeffs, CEO & CCO, Hark
30	Sarah Tulip, Digital Director, EY
32	Paul Johnson, Partner, Mills & Reeve
33	David Angrave, COO, Twinkl
34	Outstanding Leadership
36	Dan Brookman, CEO, Airship
37	Stuart Clarke, Director, Paceline
38	Ross Bray, CTO, Alps Education
39	Paul Trotter, Deputy CTO, Atom bank
40	Dave Bentley & Alex Wilkinson, CEO & COO, Solutionize Global
42	Tom Hoyland, Agile and DevOps Lead, Sky Betting & Gaming
44	Charlotte Knowles, MD, TPP
46	Biggest leadership lessons 2020
48	Peter Laflin, Head of Insight and Performance, WM Morrisons Plc
50	Simone Roche MBE, Founder & CEO, Northern Power Women
52	Yasmin Ahkter, Head of Academy, NHS Digital
53	Maureen Robson, CEO, whyaye
54	Claire Cockerton & Richelle Schuster, BUILD
55	Dr Martin Stow, Chairman and Director, NEXUS
56	Biggest challenges for 2021
58	Tim Mercer, CEO, Vapour Cloud
59	Scott Davies, Co-founder & CEO, Nightingale
60	Celine McCloughlin, Head of Product and Delivery, DWP Digital
62	Cleveland Henry, Group Delivery & Deployment Director, EMIS Plc
64	Eve Roodhouse, Chief Officer, Culture and Economy, Leeds City Council
66	Anna Sutton, CEO, The Data Shed
68	Future focus

Foreword by Roger Marsh OBE DL

The events of the year to date have demanded an authentic, empathetic, and creative response from leaders across the North.

The unprecedented public health crisis, combined with the subsequent economic fallout from the COVID-19 pandemic, has placed a great burden of responsibility upon business, community, and political leaders across our region. Amid the ongoing uncertainty, I have been impressed by the grit and determination of many of our leaders who have shown courage and innovation throughout these difficult times.

The North has a proud legacy of leading the country through moments of national difficulty, and playing an integral role in the nation's recovery. Although our region has been disproportionately affected by the pandemic, our infrastructure and capabilities will be vital to the future prosperity of the country. It is only through outstanding leadership and collaboration, however, that we will unlock the region's potential and secure a recovery which will be beneficial for all our communities.

The insight and information presented within this White Paper outline some of the world-class leadership talent we have on display throughout the North. Genuine, agile and trustworthy leadership not only has the potential to transform communities, but can also make an important difference to the lives of individuals and families across the region.

The North's capacity for innovation and reinvention goes back to the Industrial Revolution, and continues to be a hallmark of our entrepreneurs and small business owners, whose resilience, ingenuity and strong leadership are all play an even more vital role than usual in these challenging times. Often, these businesses are the ones that have been most impacted by the events of this year, but continue to demonstrate the strong leadership qualities of agility and creativity to keep their businesses afloat and their employees in work.

The outstanding leadership of those within this White Paper, as well as many others, has been vital to our region's response to this crisis, and will continue to be key to the North's recovery.

However, the courage and determination of these leaders must be matched by public sector support to address the structural inequalities that have held our region back historically. Now more than ever, our region needs central government to deliver on their levelling-up promises and provide our business and community leaders with the financial resources to unlock our region's potential to lead the nation to recovery.

Our region's leaders are well placed to bolster the nation's prosperity, from our expertise in innovation to our nation-leading energy infrastructure. The North can lead the country to Net Zero carbon by 2050, it can significantly contribute and turbo-charge our trade, and is already the home to world-renowned research institutions. To unlock this enormous potential, Northern leaders need the sustained backing of central government and the certainty and stability to take calculated risks.

Our region's business, community and political leaders have together spent much of the year to date fighting and adapting to an economic and health crisis. However, for all of their impressive qualities, which have delivered success against all the odds, our outstanding leaders need and deserve the proper support from central government to accelerate growth and secure our recovery in the national interest for decades to come. It is a shared desire amongst Northern leaders to see the full potential of the North unlocked. And it is a shared commitment to bold actions, united by a common vision for northern success - that will see further potential realised over the months and years ahead.

The North should be seen, and is, the solution for today and tomorrow.

Roger Marsh OBE DL
Chair of the NP11



Riaan De Klerk CDO, Solutionize Global

I am sure that if you were asked a year ago what your key IT priorities were for 2020, you would agree that business resiliency was important, but likely not near the top. A pandemic causes a wave of impacts across every aspect of life. Company leaders have had to contend with radical shifts in priorities at work whilst ensuring the health and wellbeing of their families and employees.

We have seen many triumphs of human collaboration and unfortunately things we all wish could have been done differently. At a financial level, organisations have been forced into stretching their current spend. Operationally, they had to increase their focus on supporting their teams as they work remotely at scale and from a technology perspective, they had to adopted new approaches to IT at speed.

We have equally seen the ingenuity, dedication and deep care for the 'doing it right' with companies coming together in a way never imaginable. From redirecting their technology purchases to the NHS, to coming together and building ventilators, and then through to - the big one - developing several vaccines at an astounding pace.

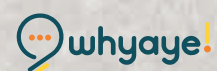
As we start to look to the future, we can be certain of one thing - we will likely never go back to "the way it was before".

Our imperative is to re-imagine how our teams work and develop strategies to improve their end-end experience, support and productivity. Security is an ever-increasing area of concern as the threat-footprint dramatically increased since the start of Covid-19. We saw organisations fall victim to cyberattacks. The National Cyber Security Centre annual review for 2020 states 2 in 3 cyber-attacks they've dealt with are coronavirus-related. We have this great opportunity ahead of us to re-imagine how we do business, perhaps it's bringing together teams in a different way (e.g. consolidating IT, product development and marketing) or maybe it is about looking at existing digital programmes differently.

As leaders brace themselves for more uncertainty over the coming months, collaboration, strategic planning and careful procurement will be essential.

When you read through some of the inspiring stories in this White paper, I hope you will see that there are two common threads throughout. The leaders featured here care for what they do, how they do it and who they do it with. These leaders are comfortable with giving more than they would ever expect to receive back.

Our contributors



The Northern Powerhouse



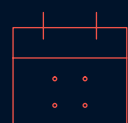
1 Year



7 Cities



12 Industry Verticals



4 Months



74 Pages



40 Contributors



2,700 minutes
of interviews



54% / 46%
Gender split



16 Key leadership
attributes



Matt
Morrisons



Samantha
NHS Digital



Sinead
Channel 4



Dan
Tribepad



Dan
Airship



Jordan
Hark



Stuart
Paceline Digital



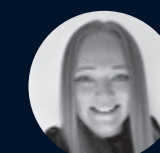
Matthew
Siemens



Rashmi
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Mel
Sheffield Digital



Charlotte
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Ross
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Mike
Hark



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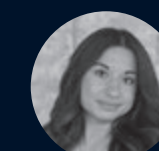
Rik
Flutter



Paul
Mills & Reeve



David
Twinkl



Vasmin
NHS Digital



Paul
Atom



Tom
Skybet



Charlotte
TPP



Peter
Morrisons



Simone
NPW



Scott
Nightingale



Maureen
whyaye



Claire
BUILD



Richelle
BUILD



Martin
NEXUS



Tim
Vapour



Anna
Data shed



Celine
DWP Digital



Cleveland
EMIS Plc



Eve
Leeds City Council



Amanda
Northern value
creators



Simon
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Roger
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Dave
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Alex
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Rachel
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Riaan
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Tom Hoyland

Agile and DevOps Lead, Sky Betting & Gaming

With a background in engineering, product development and service transformation, Tom gets under the bonnet of products, teams and organisations to understand what makes them tick and how they could be better. He's led a range of agile, DevOps and digital transformations, providing coaching and consultancy to help organisations develop high performing, resilient cultures that create innovative products and services.

What are three leadership principles you lead by?

Collaboration

As a leader it's essential to foster and encourage a climate of collaboration within and beyond your team, where people are unafraid to share ideas or concerns, no matter how embryonic or contentious.

Transparency

Be transparent in the challenges you and your team face, be honest and open in your decision making.

Commitment

Be committed to the journey and your team. Direct your energy, thought, and passion toward the goals you promote to others. Your commitment inspires, shows congruence and promotes the same commitment from others.

Name one characteristic you believe every leader should possess

Every leader should possess passion! Passion, enthusiasm and energy motivate others. A leader's passion should be conveyed in every interaction, whether this is internal comms, press releases or the narratives created. When passion, data and storytelling are combined, a powerful cocktail is created for motivating, energising and uniting teams.

What skills do you feel have helped you most in leading your team this year?

Preparation and thought space have been essential. Preparation is a given; it's essential for winning bids, delivering products and achieving the impact as intended. I believe the pandemic has encouraged leaders to 'think deeply' about problems and formulate more considered and robust solutions. Whether it be redesigning new ways of working or taking the time to analyse the physics and flow of demand, a relatively small-time investment in 'deep thought' can deliver significant dividends in terms of process improvement, effectiveness and stability.

"The past few months have highlighted the need to choose where we spend our time, how some investments yield little returns, whereas others act as force multipliers."

What has been your biggest leadership lesson of 2020?

2020 has quickly reminded leaders of the different ways in which others learn and collaborate. For me, it's highlighted the importance of supporting learning needs as a first priority, providing the right tools and time to think and collaborate, and supporting staff as they tread their own paths, piecing together their map of the world.

What will be leaders' biggest challenges in 2021 and beyond?

Remote working, trust and how we measure effectiveness. As teams have shifted to remote working, a traditional presentee-oriented view of what a 'normal' working day looks like has been fundamentally challenged. In 2021 leaders will have to make critical decisions on how to measure performance and impact, whilst providing even better tooling to ensure teams stay connected. In 2020 we trusted our workforce to collaborate autonomously. In 2021 it's essential that this trust be grown even further.

Can you name 1 standout thing you will do differently in the future, based on your experiences over the last 6-12 months?

Understanding the value of time well spent. The past few months have highlighted the need to choose where we spend our time, how some investments yield little returns, whereas others act as force multipliers. In 2021 I'll be thinking very carefully about how I spend my time, and not be afraid to say 'no' a little more often.

Where do you see the biggest challenges within your infrastructure when reflecting on the last 6 months, and looking to the future?

Investment in user experience across every interaction has become a critical foundation for continued success. Whatever the next year brings, a new level of expectation has been created through the surge in remote working. As we return to our offices, these standards and learnings will become the new baseline and normal for work. It's up to the leaders of today and tomorrow to continue supporting flexibility and the user experience, whilst preparing to iterate it, optimise it and improve it in 2021.

"Be committed to the journey and your team. Direct your energy, thought, and passion toward the goals you promote to others."